# Creating a respectful learning environment

Are expectations for respectful participation clear?



## WHAT IS IT?

Explicit norms for respectful, psychologically safe engagement are set so students can contribute and take risks

## WHY DOES IT MATTER?

Teaching is never neutral. Choices about readings, cases, examples, guest speakers, classroom norms and professional pathways tell students whose lives and knowledge are considered normal, legitimate or peripheral. When students cannot recognise themselves or their communities in the discipline, participation can start to feel risky or pointless.

## THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “People like me do not seem to exist in this field.”
- “We only appear when the course is discussing disadvantage or a problem.”

## HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Co-create or clearly state discussion norms early.
- Name the value of disagreement without humiliation or dismissal.
- Return to the norms when a difficult conversation or tense moment arises.

## EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

A tutor opens the semester by naming how the class will discuss contested issues and how students can disagree respectfully.

## STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

In this course, we aim to set and reinforce clear expectations for respectful and psychologically safe participation. If the way a class or learning activity is organised makes it harder for you to participate or understand…

## GO FURTHER AT UQ

View the Connected Citizens and Respectful Leaders example

Inclusive practice

Students as Partners